EARLY 19TH-CENTURY BATTLES



The Battle of Navarino
The destruction of the Turkish-Egyptian fleet at Navarino by the French, British, and Russian allies was the last battle under sail. Here, an exploding Turkish frigate illuminates the approaching allied vessels. The 84-gun French ship *Breslau* (left) fires a broadside into the Turks.

THE EARLY DECADES of the 19th century were the final years of the age of sail. Up to 1815 this was a time of major warfare—not only the Napoleonic Wars in Europe but also a stiff contest between the United States and Britain in the three-year War of 1812. After 1815, however, a period of comparative peace ensued, especially at sea. The position of superiority enjoyed by Britain's Royal Navy on the world's oceans was overwhelming and unchallenged. The French, still with the world's second largest navy, had neither the power nor the inclination to stop Britannia ruling the waves. The destruction of an Ottoman fleet at Navarino in 1827 was the last major fleet engagement of the 19th century, because a full-scale challenge to British hegemony was impossible.

FOUNDING A TRADITION

The United States founded a naval tradition by fits and starts in this period. Anti-militarist instincts, which had seen the Continental Navy disbanded after the Revolutionary War, were overcome in 1794 when Congress agreed to build six frigates, which were soon supported by more warships as threats to American merchant shipping mounted. The US Navy saw action against France in the undeclared Quasi-War of 1798 to 1800 (responding to French attacks on American merchant ships trading with France's enemy Britain) and against the Barbary pirates in the Mediterranean. War with Britain in 1812 presented a challenge on a quite different scale. It gave the American heavy frigates a chance to show their exceptional fighting qualities in a series of successful duels with British warships, while American victories in lake battles played an important role in inhibiting British military operations inland.

Inevitably the power of the Royal Navy predominated by the end of the conflict, but the United States emerged with a valuable stock of naval heroes, such as Stephen Decatur and Oliver Hazard Perry, and tales of derring-do to provide inspiration for the future. The US Navy remained a small force to the end of the age of sail—it never commissioned a ship of the line—but it had won acceptance as a necessary and respected institution.



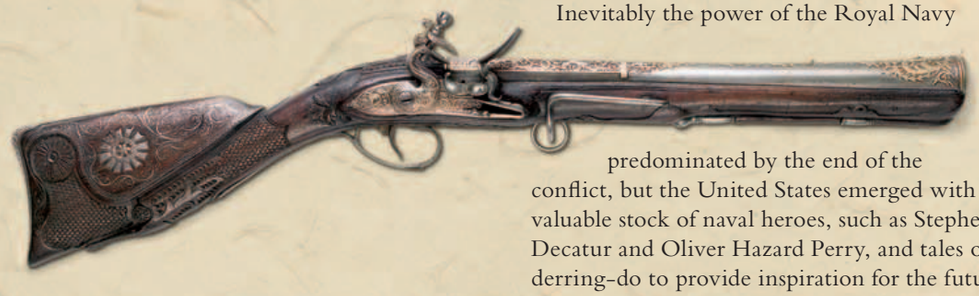
The Star-Spangled Banner
This is the flag seen by Francis Scott Key flying over Fort McHenry, Baltimore, during a British bombardment in 1814. It inspired him to write *The Star-Spangled Banner.*

ROYAL NAVY AT PEACE

The advent of peace with France and the United States in 1815 inevitably brought sharp cutbacks in Britain's war-swollen Royal Navy. By 1817 Royal Navy officers in active service stood at below a quarter of wartime numbers, and naval seamen at around a sixth of the full wartime complement. The number of British naval ships in commission fell from 713 in 1814 to 121 in 1818. This was still considered sufficient muscle for Britain to undertake the role of policeman of the oceans, in which capacity it attempted to impose a unilaterally declared ban on slave trading and took action to suppress piracy, most famously in the bombardment of Algiers, a nest of Barbary pirates, in 1816.

LIBERATION WARS

Much of the warfare in the aftermath of the Napoleonic Wars arose from the birth of national liberation movements that sought freedom from foreign rule. In South America, a series of wars was fought, firstly for independence from the colonial rule of Spain, and subsequently to define the frontiers of the new states. In Europe the Greeks fought a liberation war against the Ottoman Turks from 1821 to 1828. The independence movements could only assemble makeshift naval forces, placed under the command of imported officers such as the ubiquitous British admiral Thomas Cochrane, who served



Ottoman flintlock
Flintlock firearms had rendered the matchlock obsolete by 1700. By the early 19th century they had reached a pinnacle of sophistication, as shown by this silver-inlaid Ottoman example.